wide dispersion. Financial and manpower ceilings laid down by the Cabinet were not modified after the handing over of the northern and eastern borders to the army and border formations were expected to make do with whatever was given to them. The funds available were residual amounts after allowing for the Third Five Year Plan, which, in the wisdom of politicians and bureaucrats, remained supreme.

There were hardly any roads worth the name and the newly established Border Roads Organisation (BRO) was awaiting road building equipment from abroad. Besides Leh, the only other functional airfield was at Chushul, which had limited use as it was situated right under the nose of the Chinese in the Spanggur Gap. There were landing strips at both Fukche and Daulat Beg Oldi, but these were difficult to operate from. The Indian Air Force was desperately short of aircraft, but like the BRO, lived in the fond hope of inductions from abroad. Just how and how much was known only to the defence minister and a few select bureaucrats in the Ministry of Defence. With Bijji Kaul as the Quarter Master General (QMG), the entire focus seemed to be on keeping up appearances rather than actually solving problems on the ground.

Even as the troops in Ladakh braced themselves for a second intense winter in October 1960, there was hardly an administrative set-up in place and the scanty posts were entirely dependent on airdrops. Vast quantities of kerosene was required to keep the life-saving bukharis (oil stoves) burning, hence the IAF was hard-pressed to ferry even essential survival supplies, leaving no room for war-like stores. There was hardly any snow clothing, a chronic deficiency of tinned milk (owing to a shortage of foreign exchange) and even cooking staple food like dal was a problem. There were no pressure cookers, without which it is well-nigh impossible to cook food at high altitudes. Local commanders were at their wits' end about how to convince 'Finance' to sanction these vital and essential items. 'Finance' on the other hand, seemed to live with the paranoia of sanctioning any item that could then become a 'precedent'.

Food supplies and accommodation apart, the other major problem pertained to the evacuation of casualties. There were no field hospitals and with the posts so far apart, any medical emergency could only be met with helicopters that were in very short supply at the time. No wonder then, that Nehru's statement announcing that '…necessary preparations have been made for the defence of Indian territory' was met with raised eyebrows and